

weekend

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LESSONS IN CHEMISTRY

Lili Reinhart and Tom Bateman spill the beans on *The Love Hypothesis*, and the science of romance **P4**

metro

PLUS THE HINDU



‘The Earth is a spaceship and our bodies are spacesuits,’ says Benedict Cumberbatch. The actor discusses presenting *How to Live on Earth*, and finding hope in environmental storytelling

Sherlock shows how

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enedict Cumberbatch is possibly the only person who can get away with using a word like “trepidatious” in conversation. The actor, who captured our collective imagination as Sherlock, and has gone on to comfortably inhabit the Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU), as well as smaller films, used the word when talking about

presenting *How to Live on Earth*. The Open Planet documentary premiered on YouTube on September 20. Speaking over a video call from London, Benedict says the question, ‘How to live on Earth?’, fascinated him. “I wanted to find out. I’d worked with Fredi (Devas, director) before on a documentary about the Antarctic, (remember penwing, penling?) which I did the voiceover for in New Zealand during the lockdown in 2020.”

It was when he read the script that Benedict felt “slightly

trepidatious because there is really only one presenter of natural history documentaries, Sir David Attenborough. I was keen not to tread on those heels or be lost in trying to be that person.”

Three-pillared approach

*How to Live on Earth* is a very different flavour and character, the *Dr Strange* actor says. “It drew me in with its humour, and also the revelations of the three-pillared approach that subtitled the film, which is ‘How to Feed the Future’, ‘How to Value Nature’ and ‘How to

be Human?” Executive producer Jonnie Hughes says Benedict was the right choice because they wanted to take a different tone with the story. “It needed to reach into people’s hearts and minds. Benedict’s back catalogue is perfect in terms of global reach. He has the air of a storyteller with an intellectual argument.”

Walk the talk

The documentary’s use of experts include wildlife filmmaker and explorer, Dan O’Neill, climate justice activist, Xiye Bastida, and former White House chef and senior policy advisor on nutrition, Sam Kass, who helped Benedict present with authority. “They are extraordinary and I felt bolstered for the part that I play. That’s what I like to do in my advocacy. I’m not a policy expert, a scientist or a biologist. I’m not part of an indigenous people with ancestralism.”

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While he broke many rules of independent filmmaking, such as choosing to make it in English, instead of a regional language, the journey so far has given him the confidence to make more films. "I've already written my next screenplay, and again this city is a very important part of that story," says Munavar, who hopes to take *Chasing Rahul* to other cities, too. "Once things settle down, I can go back to polishing my script," he says.

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Lili Reinhart and Tom Bateman talk about the rom-com adaptation of Ali Hazelwood's bestselling novel, and bringing Olive and Adam's grumpy-meets-sunshine romance to the big screen

# Science meets swoon

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Much has been said about actor Lili Reinhart's looks for the whirlwind press tour leading up to the release of the American rom-com *The Love Hypothesis*. From Kate Hudson's butter-yellow slinky gown in *How To Lose a Guy In 10 Days*, to the iconic brown slip dress inspired by Jennifer Garner in *13 Going On 30*, and the short lavender mini reminiscent of Sandra Bullock in *Miss Congeniality* – scores of Instagram reels and fashion blogs have been singing her praises and celebrating her for finally putting some respect on the rom-com genre.

But when we sit down for a virtual roundtable, it is Tom Bateman's T-shirt which is the standout fashion statement of the day. The British actor is wearing a white *Notting Hill* T-shirt, with Julia Roberts and Hugh Grant emblazoned on it, a very fitting rom-com tribute from his side, indeed.

An adaptation of Ali Hazelwood's eponymous smash-hit novel which helped pioneer the STEMist

romance genre (prominently featuring women in STEM as protagonists), the movie, directed by Claire Scanlon, has Lili and Tom play Olive Smith, a sweet, PhD student and Dr Adam Carlsen, a largely grumpy, young professor nicknamed Dr Evil by his peers and students respectively; who find themselves entangled in a fake, on-campus relationship.

"I had read the book once before and I loved it. When I decided to do the film, it was always in my trailer and I had its essence and influence around me, but for me it was also important at some point to let the book simply just live in my subconscious, and do my job," Lili says.

After her breakout role as Betty Cooper in the CW series *Riverdale*, Lili went on to star in the films *Hustlers*, *Chemical Hearts*, *Forbidden Fruits*, and was more recently seen in the music video of 'Swim', by K-pop group BTS.

Two weeks into the press tour is when this roundtable happens, and Lili says it has been a revelation for her, to discover in real time as to how many people love the book. "I realise what an honour it is... to be able to play Olive."

She is almost glad, she says, of not having discovered just how beloved the book is, before and during filming. "I would have then felt a lot more intimidated. For me, it was simple; I am an actor, I was hired for a reason, and I showed up

to play Olive as I want to play her. The excitement, joy and fun of playing a character far outweighs the fear of backlash for your casting."

### The science of romance

For her co-star Tom, starring in a rom-com brings with it a special sort of excitement and he laughs as he recalls his agent very hesitantly asking if he would be up for a romance like this one. "When I first read the script, I remember loving Adam Carlsen for who he is, how he starts out, and the journey he goes on, to reveal his true self."

There has been much debate about how cinema could do with more rom-coms and in Tom, *The Love Hypothesis* seems to have found a lead who approaches the genre with a rather philosophical, and reverential affection.

"I think the reason I wanted to be a part of telling this story was something our director Claire (Scanlon) said to me; that we live in a world where everyone is so

separate and no one is listening to each other. The story here too, is of two people who are so far removed from each other's world, who should never meet or get along, and yet you watch them go through all these different rom-com tropes, start to listen to each other, and be moved and changed by it," he reflects.

The actor wants people to laugh and have a good time at the movies, of course, but also wants them to wonder what would happen if they attempted to understand someone from the other side of the world. "I hope that even in a small way, anyone who watches this might think there is more that we have in common, than what keeps us apart," he augurs.

The book's origins are widely known as a *Star Wars* 'Reylo' fan-fiction, which was out on the Internet in 2018 before it took shape as a romance novel and released in 2021. While Tom laughs and says he was initially quite unaware of its origins, he describes being hit by a 'tidal wave of serendipity' when he did finally find out. For the unversed, Tom's wife, actor Daisy Ridley, played Rey with Adam Driver playing Kylo Ren in the *Star Wars* sequel trilogy; the characters that inspired Olive and Adam in *The Love Hypothesis*.

"These were fantastic, well-drawn out characters with complexity and layers. Of course, that's going to inspire people to write books!" Tom laughs.

### All things awkward

Adam and Olive inhabit a professional world cluttered with hard-to-bag research grants and faculty politics, but their journeys ultimately prove to be about so much more than the science that brings them together. The grumpy-meets-sunshine romance at the core of the book, with fake-dating thrown in for good measure, has made room for plenty of comedy in its film adaptation.

"Before I got onto the set, I really wasn't thinking about the comedy because I am more of a romance girl. It wasn't until I started rehearsing these scenes that I realised how funny it could be. The script might have said something like 'an awkward hug', but it was really up to Tom and I to figure it out, and a lot of the laughs we get during screenings of the film are in reaction to the awkwardness of us trying to figure out where to put our hands," Lili laughs.

"The world is your oyster, and this genre is so wonderful because it allows actors to play around. You get to do the deep emotional things, but it also has these heightened, ridiculous situations. Given that these two people should never meet, we're just going to see what happens when we cram them into a room together," Tom says.

*The Love Hypothesis is streaming on Prime Video*



Tom Bateman and Lili Reinhart in *The Love Hypothesis*. PRIME VIDEO

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"These are experts that I am in awe of, who have lived the talk, who have walked the talk. It's key to me that I feel what I'm saying is backed up by those in the know."

### A variation of self

From mathematician Alan Turing to the coarse rancher in *The Power of the Dog*, Benedict has inhabited complex characters. Stepping into the role of a guide was a different skin to occupy, the Academy Award-nominated actor says, "It's a variation of myself. I have a natural curiosity about the world and how we ought to be living on it. I'm invested in the idea of doing better, both personally, and as a society."

The makers and Benedict refined both the voiceover and the piece to camera. "It wasn't too off the beaten track for my personality. There was a quirk to it, yes, but it wasn't a forced humour or an over-earnest tub thumping tone."

Not wanting it to look like a performance, Benedict wished for the narration to be grounded. "There's a presentational aspect to it. You have to hear and understand what I'm saying, the phrasing has to be weighted in the correct way, and you have to want to look at my face every now and again because I'm in it (*smiles*). But apart from that, it's got to come from an authentic place."



# Sherlock shows how

Making the film changed Benedict's relationship with the natural world. "It turbocharged my understanding of it. For example, I know that interacting with Nature is good for mental health and for Nature, and seeing the prisoners interact with the turtles underlined it. I know that if you allow Nature to thrive, it comes back online with its own solutions."

Seeing the emotion of the tribespeople on the removal of the dams on the Klamath River in southern Oregon and northern California and the return of the salmon was

particularly moving, Benedict says. "Every time I've watched that sequence, I've cried. The emotion is so transparent and potent, that it reaffirms my hope and belief that we do have enough humanity amongst us to make a difference."

### Lessons lost

We are a part of Nature and not apart from it, Benedict says. "The lesson has been lost, in rapid urbanisation, 200 years of capitalism, the rapid increase of automation, the separation of you and I, Descartes' 'I think therefore I am', I could

(Clockwise from left) The actor, and stills from the show. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



### Coming soon

Apart from returning as Dr Stephen Strange in Anthony and Joe Russo's *Avengers: Domsday*, scheduled for release in December 2026, Benedict Cumberbatch stars alongside Rosamund Pike and Anthony Hopkins in Guy Ritchie's *Wife & Dog*. The revenge thriller is set for release on February 19, 2027.

In 2027, he also stars in an adaptation of Jo Nesbø's 2014 novel, *Blood on Snow*. Directed by Cary Joji Fukunaga, who helmed the final Daniel Craig James Bond film, *No Time to Die*, the film, adapted by Nesbø and Ben Power, also stars Aaron Taylor-Johnson, Eva Green, Emma Laird and Ben Mendelsohn.



go on and on and on."

It has become useful, Benedict says to think of ourselves as units in a factory. "It's all about a drive to productivity and unsustainable growth. We're now putting the brakes on. What is valuable goes into the bigger picture of who we are as human beings."

### Set the controls

The Earth, Benedict says, is a spaceship. "It's got a biosphere that supports carbon-based life forms, and the bodies we inhabit are the spacesuits. We don't really need to go to Mars to prove that we're already in space. Thank you very much. So let's make this work."

A lot of modern inventions, Benedicts allows, have been helpful. "We're not to deny the advances in medicine, education and communication. It has, however, come at a cost, but we're clawing our way back."

"Our civilisation has almost given us permission to detach from Nature," Jonnie adds. "A lot of people are spiritually connected to Nature, as I know they are in India. This connection has been around much longer than the atomisation and separation from

Nature. We've got to get back on track and rejoin Nature."

"There is a reason indigenous peoples have been the spirit of Nature," says Benedict. "Those messages have been coming across in the last few decades of environmental advocacy. How to cohabit and be a part of Nature, not apart from it, is deep-seated in a humanity that has practised sustainability. It's no small surprise that some of the lessons that we're learning now are very old."

### Beyond the box office

Making *How to Live on Earth* free to watch was a conscious choice according to Benedict. "It's a completely democratic, open-source piece of material to inspire, provoke and call people to action. It's very rare that you're not worried about box office revenue. The philanthropic support through the Villars Institute Foundation and Silvania has created this amazingly impactful, funny, at times moving, and important bit of storytelling for free."

The film, Benedict says, could be re-constituted for educators, policy forums, political and social outreach. "That is something a normal cinematic or streamer release with its payroll wouldn't facilitate. It's a hugely attractive thing to be a part of and the film is revolutionary in its ambition."

*How to Live on Earth is streaming on YouTube*

(Clockwise from right) At Burma Burma; and on the menu at Sora and Burma Burma. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nivedita Jayaram Pawar

The first thing that hits you at Sora is the sheer scale of ambition. Spanning 11,000 sq ft, this Asian Peruvian restaurant, designed with Art Deco flourishes, feels less like a neighbourhood haunt and more like a space airlifted from Dubai.

While Ahmedabad is historically celebrated for its iconic street food and the belly-bursting thali, the city is now evolving into an innovative dry gastronomy hub. Without the crutch of alcohol to drive revenue, restaurateurs here are forced to focus on the quality of the food and the theatre of the experience.

The city's appetite for immersive, high-concept eateries has paved the way for spots like Bottega which serves Māla cuisine and Burma Burma which has successfully introduced the nuances of Kayan and Shan cuisines to the city. The latest sensation is Komo By Kaffa a sprawling 23,000 sq ft café with vaulted ceilings, sweeping pillars and mood lighting.

"The biggest draw for restaurateurs here is the luxury of space," says Sujit Mehta, co-founder, We Serve, a restaurant consultancy firm based in Ahmedabad. While an 18,000-45,000 sq ft footprint would be commercially unsustainable in Mumbai or Bengaluru in Ahmedabad, it allows for a multi-pronged revenue model: a restaurant, banqueting hall, and catering unit all under one roof.

"The dynamics work because each segment has a different season," Sujit explains. "When the restaurant



# Dry State, high spirits

Ahmedabad is now a destination for zero-proof, high-end gastronomy. Pause the dhokla for Nikkei, Mala and Kayan cuisine

is slow, the catering and banqueting pick up the slack." While setting up these high-spec spaces requires a significant investment, typically ranging from ₹5-7 crore, the payoff comes quickly. "Most restaurateurs see a full return on investment within 1.5-2 years. This speed is driven by an average spend of ₹1,200-1,500 per person and the security of nine-year land leases, which shields owners

from the volatility of frequent renewals," he adds.

A focus on technique

"In the aftermath of the pandemic, we saw a surge in home cooking, and availability of exotic ingredients from aged cheese to nori sheets and cactus," says Mihir Shah of Bottega restaurant. This domestic evolution has forced a professional response. "Restaurants had no choice



but to adapt to these changing tastes to keep pace with their guests. Things like hotpots, tamales, empanadas and techniques like sous-vide, balsamic caviar, and spherification are no longer alien to the local palate," he adds. "Gujaratis love to travel and seek out new culinary experiences, and they now expect that same level of sophistication at home."

Ankit Gupta, co-founder of



the Burma Burma chain, agrees, saying that when they launched two years ago, specialised dining concepts were rare. "Today, we are seeing an influx of niche formats, from Korean eateries to dedicated dessert cafés. New dining hubs like Sarkhej-Gandhinagar Highway and Prahlad Nagar have also fuelled this change," says Ankit.

This receptivity has turned Ahmedabad into a strategic launchpad; Ankit often tests new menus here before a national rollout.

Cookbook author Kamini Patel says that as family units shrink and interest in home cooking declines, dining out has moved from an occasional luxury to a lifestyle choice. Kamini says the city's youth are the primary engine behind the change. Armed with higher disposable incomes and a preference for elevated cuisine, they consistently opt for premium dining experiences over traditional meals.



The Gujarati thali remains the city's culinary soul. Here are the top thali joints in Ahmedabad:

Agashiye, The House of MG - ₹1,695  
Vishalla, Opp. APMC Market - ₹848  
Pakwan, Sarkhej - Gandhinagar Highway - ₹400  
Raj Thaal, Bopal - ₹450  
Rajwadu, Malav Talav - ₹1,050  
Gordhan Thal, Sarkhej - Gandhinagar Hwy - ₹425  
Gopi Dining Hall, Prahlad Nagar and Elis Bridge - ₹425  
Chandravilas, Gandhi Road, Old City - ₹350  
Ananda, Sindhu Bhavan Road - ₹1,155

Mocktails 2.0

For a State without alcohol, the zero-proof drinks in Ahmedabad are creating quite a splash. Mixologists are trading sugary punches for sophisticated botanicals, smoked syrups and clarified juices to build complex mocktails. These are served with the same theatricality as any high-end cocktail, using dry ice, artisanal ice blocks and house-made bitters.

At Sora, the famous Thai dessert mango sticky rice is deconstructed in a glass. A base of mango and pandan is clarified with coconut milk and then topped with warm rice foam from an ISI siphon. "Making non-alcoholic drinks is far more difficult than

people realise," says Sanyog Nikharge, head mixologist at Sora. "I personally enjoy a spirit-forward drink, so I wanted to create the same complexity, acidity and mouthfeel minus the ethanol."

Since Ahmedabad is a city of architects, some of the new restaurants are housed in stunning brutalist structures, restored havelis, or minimalist interiors. The dining aesthetic, once rooted in traditional settings, is transitioning toward a modern and often futuristic sensibility.

Take Cacaoité, for instance. Designed by Australian firm Storm Worldwide with interiors by London's LEQB, it is a literal immersion into the world of cacao. A dramatic ceiling mimics the flow of molten chocolate, while display units echo the curves of cacao pods.

Sujit notes that there is a newfound penchant for open-air settings and outdoor dining. Unlike the enclosed, air-conditioned boxes of the past, newer projects are prioritising expansive, airy layouts that blur the line between the interior and the street outside. He is currently working with design heavyweights like Mumbai-based Sumessh Menon and Delhi's Tanya Chutani of Pantone Collective, who are introducing a more global, plush visual language to local dining.

The anticipation surrounding the 2030 Commonwealth Games and a potential 2036 Olympic bid is already driving a significant wave of infrastructure and hospitality development. In the more immediate future, Ankit predicts that the growth of GIFT City and the arrival of the Bullet Train will propel the city's dining scene to match the scale of Mumbai and Bengaluru. "The city is ready for more single-cuisine restaurants," Sujit says. "The potential here is still largely unrealised."



Chambal gin's The Banjara Trail: Traveller's Edition, and (below) Pervez Bapuna. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

hibiscus, and kokum, say the executives. Upon nosing and taking the first sip, the kokum in the glass comes through. Top it off with ice and tonic and then see a hint of orange making itself known in the drink. Because it is light, this Chambal gin behaves with poise in a cocktail, showcasing its malleability, a seminal reason for its preference across genders, reveal Pervez and his wife Shireen Sheriar Bapuna who heads brand strategy for the brand.

"The reason why we have moved to the Western Ghats in this edition is because my family has roots in Nagpur. My grandfather, who always had sharp business acumen, participated in various ventures including owning a stationery shop. After entering many other fields including the wine industry, he began bottling beverages. The second generation (his father and uncles) after him began contesting for tenders in Madhya Pradesh to establish bottling units. Subsequently, we opened our own brand too," says Pervez.

Chambal gin has gone through over 40 rounds of iteration to get the perfect blend. "The name can only take you so far. At some point, you need a good, quality product. The names here capture attention but it is the spirit that will keep people," he says.

India is a whisky market with a steady proliferation of gins in the space. Are people still keen on drinking Indian gin or was it once a fad? "I don't think gin will cease to exist. Indians love to switch – but if they like the product, they come back to it," Pervez says.

The brand is soon launching a premium vodka, whiskey and an entry-level beer, Shireen adds.

Pervez says that one of the most exciting parts of making interesting spirits has been the reactions they have elicited. "People send me pictures from duty-free shops, saying they have stocked our bottles. It brings me such joy," he says.

Chambal gin's The Banjara Trail: Traveller's Edition is now available in Goa, Rajasthan, Gurgaon, Maharashtra, Bengaluru and Madhya Pradesh with a bottle ranging between ₹1,700 and ₹2,900 based on the location.



A Bavarian celebration

Raise a glass to Bavarian cheer as The Spotted Deer brings Oktoberfest 2026 to Chennai. The menu features German-inspired favourites including chicken schnitzel, Oktoberfest brisket sando and cottage cheese steak, with chocolate inception and brulee cheesecake for a sweet finish. Pair the spread with German beers, cocktails, and mocktails while soaking in the festive Bavarian atmosphere. Till October 4, 11am to 11pm at The Spotted Deer, The Palomar by Crossway. Reservations call 8925847085.

# Cheers to rani pink

Chambal's limited-edition pink gin built on orange, hibiscus and kokum proves that Indian gins are not a fad. They are here to stay

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Starting with a PJ is never a great way to begin a piece but this is how I am beating AI. What do stationery shops and alco-bev companies have in common? No, not Hemingway making the daiquiri a staple; but Pervez Bapuna's industrialist grandfather who began Bapuna Alcobrew out of Nagpur and subsequently Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh. Staple... like the stapler? Okay, never mind.

Bad jokes aside, these are several unlikely words strung together in a sentence.

Think gin, and the association is Goa. Pervez, COO, has been attempting to break that perception by bringing us a gin from the daunting wilderness of MP. It is why the alco-bev company launched Chambal, an Indian dry gin from a region infamous for dacoity, back in 2023. The original gin, with heavy notes of spice including cardamom and cinnamon, seems



to have shined through its amber bottle.

Building on the success, the company has decided to release the second in its Banjara Trail series, The Banjara Trail: Traveller's Edition, Western Ghats, a limited-edition gin bottled at 42.8 per cent ABV. This one is pink, making it inherently more drinkable.

Unlike the original spiced version, the Banjara trail gin derives its name from the eponymous Indian nomadic tribe and the bounties of the Western Ghat. It is light with floral and fruity notes from orange,



(Clockwise from right) Freshly caught hilsa on display at Gariahat Market; circa 1998: blocks of ice being carried to a fishing trawler moored at Diamond Harbour in West Bengal; hilsa prepared in a thick mustard gravy. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, SHREYA BANERJEE, AND THE HINDU ARCHIVES



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The journey of the hilsa begins far from the Bengali kitchen. Before the mustard paste, before the green chillies split down the middle, before the first hiss of fish meeting hot oil, it is out at sea, moving through deeper, colder water. Then the monsoon gathers, the rivers swell, and something ancient pulls the fish inland.

“It is an ocean fish,” says Sujoy Chatterjee, co-founder of the lunchroom Amar Khamar, who works with a large network of farmers and growers across West Bengal and Sunderbans for his ingredient and rare fish revival work. Sujoy says that the hilsa comes to the rivers for laying eggs.

The journey is the beginning of almost everything Bengalis later attach to hilsa: season, taste, geography, ritual, even longing. Research, Sujoy says, has recorded hilsa covering 40 to 60 kilometres in a day, sometimes even more. “There is a saying that hilsa dies for its children,” he adds. The fish leaves the sea to spawn. The young eventually travel back towards the ocean, grow there and, when their turn comes, begin the journey upriver themselves.

Sujoy recalls accounts of hilsa travelling up the Ganga as far as Kanpur before the Farakka Barrage altered the river system. Today, it enters river systems across Bengal and Bangladesh: the Ganga-Bhagirathi-Hooghly, the

# Current affairs

## Following the hilsa from ocean to river to plate reveals a story of ecology, appetite and inherited taste

Rupnarayan, the Padma, Meghna, Jamuna and their tributaries and estuaries.

### Ganga versus Padma hilsa

Ask a Bengali whether Ganga hilsa tastes better than Padma hilsa and a discussion can acquire the solemnity of constitutional debate. Ganga hilsa, he says, is often more elongated, its body whiter, sometimes carrying a silvery-golden line along the belly. Padma hilsa can appear broader, roundish, with a slightly different cast to the flesh.

Taste, however, is harder to pin down. Sujoy reaches for an agricultural analogy. “If you ask me why Gobindobhog rice grows beautifully in one part of Bardhaman, I will talk about terroir, about microclimate. With hilsa also, the ecology of the place must matter,” he notes

River depth, current, silt, water composition, and the food available to the fish may all play a role. There are old explanations that hilsa loses some of its marine salinity as it travels through fresh water, making its flesh taste sweeter. Sujoy is careful not to present every inherited theory as science, but he is fascinated by the fact that generations of people who catch and eat the fish have consistently linked taste to water.

Sujoy recalls a time when serious hilsa eaters supposedly claimed they could tell whether a fish had been caught near Babughat, Bagbazar or elsewhere along the river simply by tasting it. “It was almost like a blind tasting of wine,” he says. It is an extraordinary image: a city



### What data says

Tridge, a global agri-food market intelligence platform that tracks international trade flows, offers a snapshot of how hilsa is moving in and out of India. In June 2026, its dataset recorded 60 frozen-hilsa transactions from Myanmar to India, involving 316,696.5 kg, while India recorded three frozen-hilsa export transactions, two to Iraq and one to Malaysia. For fresh hilsa that month, 52 of 56 recorded transactions were from Myanmar to India; India, in turn, recorded two exports each to the UK and US. By July 2026, Tridge recorded nine fresh-hilsa import transactions into India, all from Myanmar, amounting to 3,250 kg, while India exported 484 kg of fresh hilsa to the UK across eight transactions.

inherited from his grandfather. This year, most of his hilsa comes from Diamond Harbour, Canning, Lakshmikantapur, Sonakhali and Malancha, where wholesale markets, feed Kolkata’s fish trade. Hilsa is selling for ₹1,800 to ₹2,000 a kilogram, while Bangladeshi fish, he says, has not arrived at all. Much of the catch is kept in cold storage almost immediately. Hilsa, Mujibor explains, is a *sukhi*, or delicate fish, that dies soon after leaving the water. He has noticed another change. With pollution closer to shore, he says, more hilsa are moving towards the cleaner waters of the high seas, where much of this year’s catch is coming from. Mujibor adds, “Hilsa is available in the off-season too, but it does not have the same flavour as the monsoon catch. During the off-season, prices usually range between ₹1,200 and ₹1,400 per kg.”

### Environmental effects

The fish’s life depends upon movement between marine and freshwater ecosystems. Rising ocean temperatures can affect plankton, one of its principal food sources. Changes in oxygen levels, river depth and water temperature can influence migration. Pollution alters river ecology. Deep-sea fishing can intercept fish before they reach the rivers to spawn.

There is also growing concern, Sujoy says, about hilsa maturing at smaller sizes. When consumers expect hilsa in every month of the year and are prepared to pay for it, supply responds. “Why not respect the seasonality? Have hilsa when it is at its best. At other times, celebrate the local fish, the smaller fish,” notes Sujoy.

Hilsa possesses an intricate bone structure, and anyone watching an experienced Bengali eat it may wonder whether a small surgical procedure is underway.

Hilsa appears in poems, proverbs, ritual and rain, in East Bengal-West Bengal arguments and inherited kitchen rules. It has inspired people to distinguish rivers by taste. It can be discussed as marine biology in one breath and as an aunt’s *jhol* in the next.

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When people talk about visiting the Northeast – the land of seven sisters – one State almost always gets left off the list: Tripura. Unless you have family there or work that takes you there, it rarely makes it onto anyone’s itinerary. As someone from the Northeast myself, I have often wondered: what is there to see and experience in Tripura?

Chapter, the new lifestyle hospitality brand from Polo Hotels Group, one of the Northeast’s leading homegrown hospitality groups, will make its debut with Chapter Lakeside in Tripura on October 11. Chapter Lakeside, Tripura, is a 17-key, destination-led, design-forward brand built to scale with purpose while giving travellers a way into the character of each State. Chapter is also being positioned as the first homegrown hospitality brand to emerge from the region in nearly 30 years, making its launch in the relatively underexplored State of Tripura particularly significant. The price for rooms, including breakfast, range from ₹11,999 to ₹22,499 per night for two, plus 18% GST.

I got a chance to chat with Deval Tibrewalla, Whole Time director and CEO, Hotel Polo Towers. “Ours is an upscale boutique brand built on a simple guiding principle: the place comes first,” Deval told me. “Design, food, art, music and experiences start with the destination, then get edited into a sharp, contemporary hotel. Its pools, spas and restaurants are not add-ons. They are part of the way guests read the place.”

The Tripura property sits on the shores of Rudrasagar Lake, about 90 minutes from Agartala



# North star

Chapter Lakeside focusses on Tripura with Neermahal views, local flavours and craft revealing the Northeast anew



airport, with views of Neermahal Palace from the pool and most rooms. A lake-view pool, poolside bar, all-day dining and boat transfers make the lake part of the experience rather than just scenery.

Talking to Deval, I realised how much of Tripura I did not know – its palaces, wildlife and ancient rock-cut carvings. He was equally animated about the food: a cuisine built around herbs, ferments and different varieties of rice, distinct from much of the region.

What stayed with me was an idea he calls the “animal in residence”. Each Chapter property is built around an animal that represents its State – the spectacled langur for Tripura, the hill myna for Meghalaya – and the creature becomes the design spine of the property. “The localness is in the fabric of the thing, not the story told around it,” he said. At Chapter Lakeside, local furnishings and food follows the same principle, including berma (fermented fish of



Tripura) and oil-free Tripuri cooking. Tripura is also a major biodiversity hotspot for bamboo, with more than 21 species found across the State, while its cane is regarded as among the finest in the country.

For Deval, “upscale” isn’t about surface polish. “It’s not an expensive wallpaper,” he said. “Wise decisions, aesthetic

concepts coupled with visual and spatial concepts make it upscale. Build the pool where the view is best from. Cook food from the region. Build a bar with a point of view. Keep it sharp, warm and local. That is Chapter.”

The Northeast is seeing growing traveller interest, improved connectivity and more investment in destination infrastructure. Through Chapter, Polo Hotels Group is betting on places that have largely remained outside the mainstream leisure circuit, with the hope that tourism can also bring jobs and upskilling to local hospitality talent.

At the centre of the food story is Cassette Kitchen & Bar, where ingredients come from tea gardens, hill markets and local growers. The cooking draws from Kokborok and Mui Borok traditions. The bar works with local botanicals and Tripura’s craft beverage culture. “The Northeast isn’t a theme here; it’s simply where the kitchen starts,” the team says.

Cassette Kitchen & Bar is Tripura’s tribute to RD Burman, while its Meghalaya counterpart pays homage to rock and roll.



### Flavours of the South

Take a vegetarian trip through South India at Rasanai’s Great Saiva Festival, bringing together street-food favourites from Tamil, Kannadiga, Andhra/Telugu and Malayali kitchens. The menu includes periyakadai veethi javvarisi bonda with kara chutney, saiva eeral varuval, bunglow saiva meen varuval, Mangalore buns with mock chicken gassi and rose badam kalalandu pongal. Plant-based mock meat and seafood dishes recreate the char, spice and textures of classic street food without the meat. Expect everything from shopping-street roasts and Malabar tapioca cutlets to Mangalorean ghee roasts and Chettinad-style chutneys. Till September 30, Rasanai, Besant Nagar. ₹1,900 for two approximately. Reservations at 8925915856.



### When the night unfolds

Lifestyle label Nicobar’s Autumn/Winter 2026 collection pays an ode to the ‘pre-festive glow of Godavari’. Titled NicoSera, after sera, the Italian word for evening, the collection moves away from seasonal dressing towards a ‘permanent evening vocabulary’. It features sculptural silhouettes, fluid forms and tactile surfaces in ink black, deep navy, bluish purple, burgundy, molten gold, and liquid silver. The womenswear capsule includes 18 pieces, from tissue organza sets and cotton-silk overlays to backless halter dresses. Menswear features pintucked cotton satin shirts with beaded bird motifs and adda-work florals.

Priced upwards of ₹4,500, available at Nicobar stores and online.



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From his breakthrough hit ‘Aur Bantai’ to ‘Safal’, Emiway looks back on his journey and the changing hip-hop landscape, speaking about authenticity, and the responsibility that comes with a growing audience

# The Bantai way

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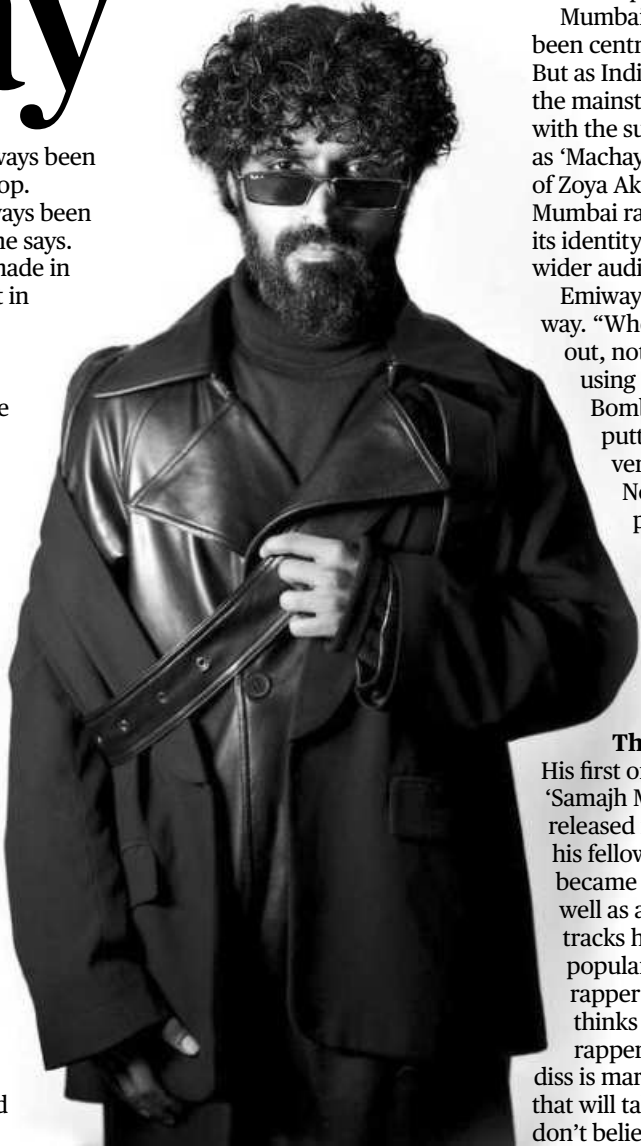
Emiway Bantai calls himself the G.O.A.T. (Greatest of All Time). Or, in his own words, “fans bolte hain GOAT, toh waqt ke saath GOAT ho gaye apun” (Fans call me the G.O.A.T, so over time, I became the G.O.A.T.) It is a typical Emiway take on his journey – a mix of humour, swagger, and self-awareness. Over the past decade, the Mumbai rapper has gone from independently putting out music to becoming one of Indian hip hop’s most recognisable voices. Born Bilal Shaikh, he took his stage name from two of his early influences, Eminem and Lil Wayne. He began releasing music in 2013, with ‘Aur Bantai’ which put him on the map. In 2019, ‘Machayenge’ became a breakout hit.

For Season 4 of Red Bull 64 Bars, Emiway returns with his new single ‘Safal’ co-produced with Memax, in collaboration with Def Jam Recordings India. The series brings together artistes who draw from distinct regional identities, something

Emiway believes has always been intrinsic to Indian hip hop. “Indian hip-hop has always been diverse from day one,” he says. “It’s not like rap is not made in Hindi. Some are doing it in English, some in Hindi, even Marathi, Gujarati, and Punjabi.”

What has changed, he says, is visibility. “Every language is getting its own shot. Especially since Red Bull’s 64 Bars is a heavy platform, where all languages are getting the limelight properly, along with the emerging artistes.”

He wanted the track to work for his existing audience, while also introducing new listeners to the mechanics of rap. “I aimed to make sure my fans could understand it, while also helping the new audience coming in understand how we engage people through our words, our flow, and our skills.”



So what comes first when Emiway writes? “For me, it’s different every time.” For instance, his upcoming project is entirely freestyle. “I put on the mic, played the beat and didn’t write anything. Nothing on paper, nothing in my notes. The beat was playing, and I was freestyling straight into the mic. *Beat batata hai ki humko kya chahiye*” (Beat tells us what we want).”

The other source is the street. A random conversation, a stranger’s sentence, can also become material. “You think, ‘Arre bhai, what an interesting thing he said.’ It stays in your mind. When you get back to the studio, you put those words down on paper,” he says.

Mumbai street slang has long been central to Emiway’s music. But as Indian hip-hop entered the mainstream around 2019-20, with the success of tracks such as ‘Machayenge’ and the release of Zoya Akhtar’s *Gully Boy*, did Mumbai rap risk losing some of its identity in the race to reach a wider audience?

Emiway doesn’t see it that way. “When ‘Aur Bantai’ came out, not many people were using slang like that. The Bombay street slang I was putting into my songs was very new for the scene. Now I see so many people rapping using the slang from their own gullies, streets, and areas. Everyone has their own style, and I really like that,” says Emiway.

### The ‘diss’ track

His first official diss track, ‘Samajh Mein Aaya Kya’, released in 2018 in response to his fellow rapper Raftaar, became a huge controversy as well as applause. While diss tracks have always been a popular aspect of every rapper’s career, Emiway thinks otherwise. “Many rappers think that doing a diss is marketing or promotion, that will take us forward. But I don’t believe in that.” For him, a

diss needs a reason behind it. “If something has happened to you, and you felt bad about it, then you obviously need to give an answer. But if you think that without any reason I will make a diss and become famous, that won’t happen.”

Emiway’s international collaborations, with Snoop Dogg and Macklemore meanwhile, have given him a different perspective on how Indian hip-hop is viewed outside the country. “In the market, there are numerous options where you can monetarily give money and make these collaborations. But I have never taken that path. *Jo approaches aaye, woh saamne se aaye*,” he says.

He believes Indian audiences themselves have helped change that perception. “Here you have the audience, and the numbers. People from outside have finally realised that the Indian audience is dangerous.”

For Emiway, that reach also comes with responsibility. Since the beginning of his rap career, he has used his music to address issues including sexual violence, women’s rights, and environmental concerns. More recently, he released ‘Bolra Hai Sadak’ in connection with the CJP protest at Jantar Mantar. “When you have such a large audience, and you have the pen in your hand, you automatically have that responsibility. *Mera manna hai ki main janta ke liye hoon*,” he says.

“There is also no political angle. Here I am just the voice of the people,” he adds.

When he started, he remembers watching his music go from 100 views to 1,000, with a lakh views feeling like a dream. Today, the numbers are vastly different, but he thinks newer rappers have an opportunity he did not have. His advice is simple: “What you are, be that. Do your own style and keep it real.”

“*Emiway Bantai ko jo banaya hai wo Almighty hai*,” he says. “Put God first. That’s it.”



### Emmy’s nod to India

India has two entries at the 2026 International Emmy Awards, with SonyLIV’s *Real Kashmir Football Club* nominated in the Drama Series category and Vir Das’ Netflix special *Fool Volume* in Comedy. Based on the real-life story of Real Kashmir FC, the series stars Manav Kaul and Mohammed Zeeshan Ayyub and follows the journey of the first professional football club from Jammu and Kashmir. Das, meanwhile, has made history as the only Indian to receive three International Emmy nominations. He was previously nominated for *Vir Das: For India* and *Vir Das: Landing*, which won the award.



### OM release postponed

Dhanush and Mammooty-starrer *OM: Chapter 1* will not release on October 16 as planned. Dhanush announced the postponement on September 23, citing Rajinikanth’s *Jailer 2*, which is scheduled to release a day earlier, on October 15. The actor said the decision was made out of respect for Rajinikanth. The film will also skip the Deepavali window, with Suriya’s *Scene* already announced for November 6. Directed by Rajkumar Periasamy, *OM: Chapter 1 – Udhiram: The Blood Wood* features Dhanush, Mammooty, Sai Pallavi, Sreeleela and Naseeruddin Shah. The action drama, backed by Dhanush’s Wunderbar Films and R Take Studios, is planned as the first part of a two-part franchise. A new release date is yet to be announced.

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Hindi

Kunal Kemmu aims for stars



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There's comfort in letting Kunal Kemmu be Kunal Kemmu. His animated buffoonery has shaped itself over the years whether it is the mix of his flirty bad-boyish excesses in *Dhol* and *Go Goa Gone*, the no-brainer antics of the *Golmaal* films or the recent touch of innocence that came spilling through Netflix's *Single Papa*. Kemmu invokes it all in his sophomore directorial *Vibe*, playing a serial tripper, Hardik, who feels like an updated version of his past comedic characters, always having a one-line up his sleeve, as he painfully navigates through unexpected situations with his instinctive comic timing. However, none of it proves enough for *Vibe* as Kunal Kemmu (the writer-director), relies far too much on the spontaneity of Kunal Kemmu (the actor), forgetting the propulsive riches of his debut, *Madgaon Express*, where the comedy progressed beat-by-beat into a hilarious outing. He struggles to match his own *vibe* the second time around.

The troubles start showing up early on as the screenplay hastily switches between characters and plot lines. One of them begins with Bhagirath (Sparsh Srivastava), a serious hustler working at a software company where he traps his boss into employing Hardik, his good-for-nothing, stoner best-buddy from school.

Vibe

Director: Kunal Kemmu

Cast: Kunal Kemmu, Preity Zinta, Sparsh Srivastava, Yashpal Sharma, Dinesh Lal Yadav

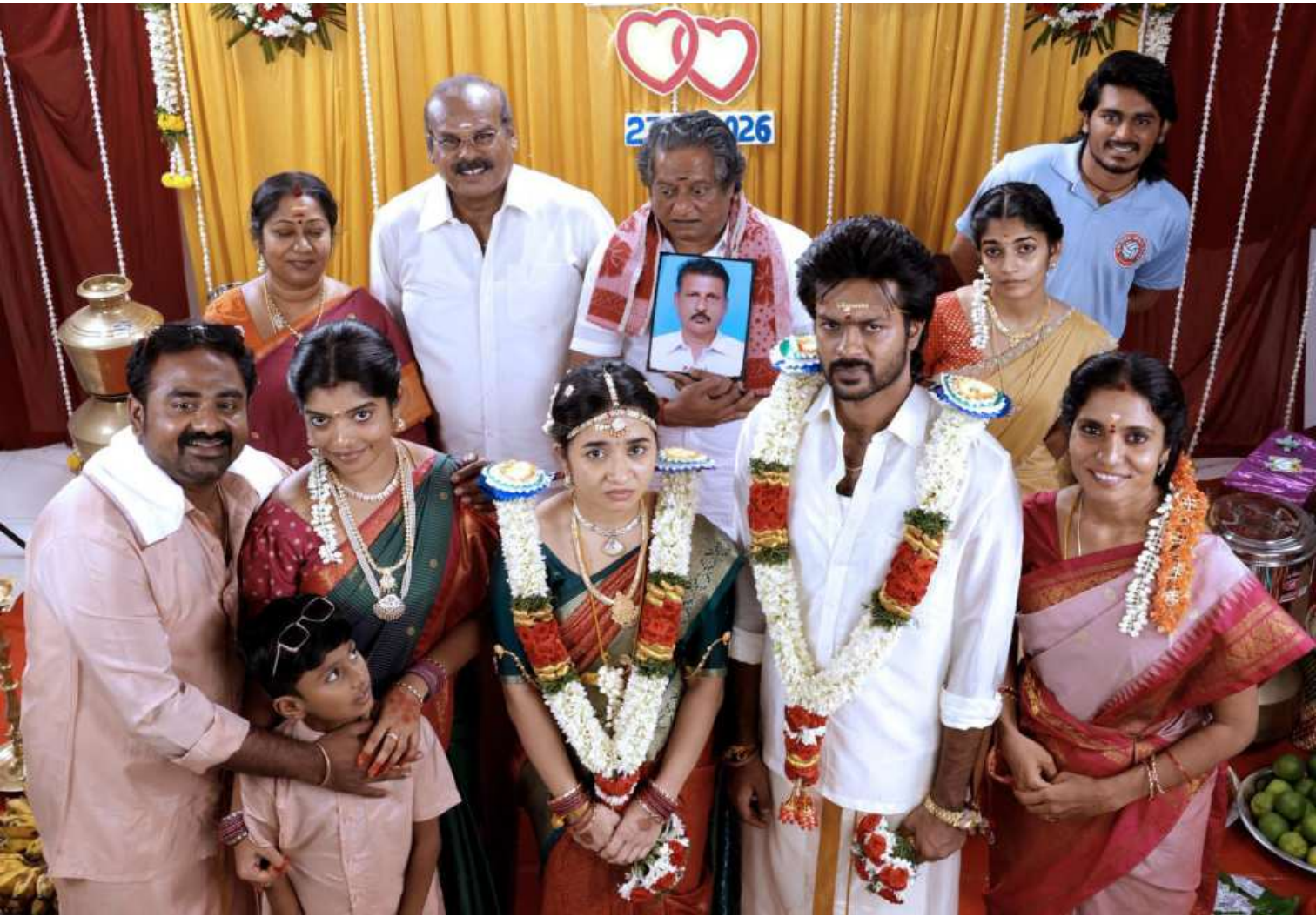
Synopsis: Two best buddies are pulled into an unlikely terror conspiracy that puts them in unexpected comedic situations as they navigate along with their conflicting personalities

It is difficult to really situate Hardik's humanity in the story as Kemmu's writing never lets him follow one characteristic. The tone keeps shifting as Hardik immodestly flirts with an office intern Kareena (Vanshika Dhar), often imposing his liking with borderline creepiness. Kemmu treats Hardik with a strange ambiguity, often normalising his ill-manners under the garb of humour.

The focus stays perennially on Hardik, and Kemmu is capable of livening moments even when the writing doesn't offer as much support. He remains watchable with his inimitable, buoyant voice, right from the first time it is heard before the opening credits through the brand logos and special thanks section. "The movie is about to start," he says while mildly roasting the practise. There's great promise of a self-aware, chirpy flick even before the first frame comes up. But Kemmu withdraws from the path and chooses another, longer and laborious one instead, where he is the center of his own world, sagging beneath his own image, as he deifies himself with an introductory slow-mo sequence over pumped up music, following that up with another similar moment of superstar machismo in the climax.

Where's the goofy Kunal Kemmu in all this? Where's the 'Josh hai to hausle hai, chidiya hai to ghosle hai...' rigour from *Golmaal 3*? The sophomore spark fizzles out soon. Here's hoping that the third time's a charm.

Vibe is currently running in theatres



A hilarious, poignant comedy-drama

Raja Karupphasamy's well-acted, deceptively simple film turns a chaotic wedding night into a tender portrait of the strange ways fate brings people together

Tamil

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A temple priest chides his lord, a folk deity, for not giving it back to the villagers who have somehow always managed to disrespect both the deity and the priest. The latest misstep was sticking posters on the temple walls for a wedding they weren't formally invited to. "Show them you are here every once in a while," urges the priest, and for the next 140-odd minutes, this is what happens. Let me clarify: this isn't a *saami padam*, which seems to be the season's theme. This is debutant director Raja Karupphasamy's *Modha Rathri*, a comedy-drama that taps into the well of human emotion and is in equal parts hilarious and heartfelt.

But I stand by what I said; the supernatural plays a central role. Not inviting the priest (played by the ever-impressive Chetan), who we realise is the groom's uncle, is the first "saamikutham" that imperils the wedding between Maruthanayagam (Rishikanth) and Muthuselvi (Anishma Anilkumar). In this world, superstitions might be true. Before a furniture owner finishes saying how auspicious the day is, his worker gets in his way with a log of wood – the same worker whose mistake will send them on an unforgettable night carrying a bed they made for the titular nuptial night. Even the tolls of a temple bell at the right time carry immense meaning, as "a divine approval," leading to how the plot moves.

All of this is intentional, for at the thematic centre of it all, Raja's film defines the divine more broadly as 'fate' or

Modha Rathri

Director: Raja Karupphasamy

Cast: Rishikanth, Anishma Anilkumar, Shelly Kishore, Abdoool Lee

Storyline: A reluctant groom and an unwilling bride find themselves stuck together on their wedding night, as one mishap after another forces them to confront their circumstances



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'destiny.' This is essentially a story about how one fateful night brings together two distinct people who oddly seem to fit like yin and yang due to their situations and what they lost to get there – with some help from destiny.

The inauspicious event that shut the temple's well also plunged Maruthu into darkness; we don't get the full picture immediately, but even after spending five years in Dubai, Maruthu still lives merely as a reminiscence of who he was. The weary eyes of Rishikanth (who we will soon see in *Dorothy*) carry the weight of Maruthu's past so effortlessly that you don't question him when his uncle (Abdoool Lee in his element) manages to guilt-trip and coerce him into agreeing to a marriage he had no clue about on the day of the wedding.

At least Maruthu's position is clear. The weather in Selvi's world changes so rapidly that her plight almost rage-baits the viewer. Selvi, too, isn't interested in the wedding and plans to elope with her good-for-nothing boyfriend (aced by director Raja himself). Except the latter messes up the plan by – wait for it – oversleeping! Anishma, who was superb in *Sirai* and *Youth*, assuredly conveys Selvi's increasing disillusionment, bewilderment, and the emotional weight of realising her dire situation. Maruthu and Selvi get married, and this ticking time bomb explodes with laughs, tears and poignancy over the titular *modha rathri*.

In his first directorial effort, Raja surprises with how assuredly he pulls off the humour. It's a hoot whenever the many subplots intersect. But the film also has many minor moments that leave you in stitches – like a hilarious moment involving Selvi on stage or what happens to her boyfriend on his way to her home in the dead of night. An innovative idea

involves the boyfriend's two friends who 'torment' him through his conscience.

Every character in this film has their own shortcomings, and Raja seamlessly taps into those traits for laughs and bigger statements. Muthu's maternal uncle Saravanan (Bagavathi Perumal) annoys you with his tantrums. However, a grown man holding his late brother-in-law's picture and struggling with low self-esteem and life's reality seems juvenile and pitiful. If the characters don't make you laugh, they make you think. You think about how people treat the wage worker who works at a family function. The characters make you ponder the many women who still have to fight to get higher education. While the whole village can unite for a wedding, they won't stand with a lone man protesting for their future.

The way these colourful characters – who are found in most families – interact with one another is something to watch, and it's no wonder Raja's film has clicked with families; even the adult jokes the in-laws crack aren't crass, but resemble how most gossiping relatives speak.

Of course, despite the well-written scenes in the second half, many might have reservations about how the film resolves the conflict. In the climax, you start to wonder whether the central storyline about Maruthu and Selvi could have used more heft. But by then, Raja would have already made you ponder Maruthu going, "You at least have questions to ask." You would already be thinking about how most marriages, as the priest says, do not happen for the right reasons. Or you might like how even the divine, through the priest, cannot do it all at the end of the night. *Modha Rathri* is a night to remember.

Modha Rathri is streaming on Netflix

Life beyond the bedroom door

Hindi

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If the birth of *Lust Stories* was a shout for liberation, a tearing down of the velvet curtains that long hid Indian intimacy, then the third iteration is the echo. Helmed by a new set of original voices – Shakun Batra, Vikramaditya Motwane, Kiran Rao, and Vishal Bhardwaj – and bolstered by an ensemble of actors who translate subtext through the vocabulary of body language, it does not seek to shock, nor does it carry the heavy burden of breaking taboos. It treats desire not as a provocative statement, but as a messy mirror.

The four-part anthology shows how physical proximity often masks isolation in modern relationships. It shows how lust is weaponised, bargained with, or surrendered to. In the earlier films of the franchise, the stories followed a clear arc of liberation, a character realising their worth or claiming their pleasure.



Here, within the recognisable OTT beats, the liberation is rarely external. In three segments, intimacy is readily available, but real emotional safety is scarce.

But what happens when intimacy dries up in married life? In Motwane's closely observed short, two wives from Mumbai's Kandiwali, drawn to Korean shows, come up with creative ideas to reclaim their desire. It treats a tragic emotional crisis with the sharp, biting edge of situational comedy. By refusing to

turn their sexless marriages into a melodramatic soap opera, Motwane finds the ludicrousness in human desperation and turns marital rejection into a cynical joke. Konkona Sen Sharma and Radhika Apte excel as women trapped in quiet erasure.

It is refreshing to see Konkona break out of the stoic moulds she is often cast in, and Radhika channel her character's frustration into a kind of physical energy that is overpowering in a good way. Vijay

Varma and Abhishek Banerjee play the husbands with such natural, everyday complacency that they give Radhika and Konkona a concrete wall to bounce their desperation against.

Batra's approach is sharper and much more relatable as he once again makes us care for two messed-up souls. In this psychological warfare, Saili (Radhika Madan) and Varun (Ali Fazal) are seeking divorce, but their bodies haven't given up on each other. When words ruin everything, sex is their way to communicate.

Set in the 1980s, Vishal Bhardwaj's poetic examination of love shifts the traditional power of the gaze to the female character, and the physical dynamic gradually becomes a subversive commentary on how agency operates on screen. Aditi Rao Hydari is usually cast as an idealised, ethereal romantic interest. Still, Bhardwaj tears down this archetype as she plays a literature teacher in a 'girls' college who reads Manto aloud. A woman who understands that a story's beauty resides in its slow, deliberate prologue, Saira returns home to a doctor husband (Siddharth) who approaches intimacy

like a clinical procedure, rushing to an abrupt conclusion before the first chapter can even begin. Egged on by her curious students, Saira writes an erotic novel that captures the implicit longing of her bedroom but is consumed by guilt of breaking tradition.

However, unlike the preceding

Lust Stories 3

Directors: Vikramaditya Motwane, Kiran Rao, Shakun Batra, Vishal Bhardwaj

Cast: Konkona Sen Sharma, Radhika Apte, Ali Fazal, Radhika Madan, Siddharth, Aditi Rao Hydari, Vijay Verma, Abhishek Banerjee

Storyline: Four stand-alone narratives trace the volatile boundaries of modern intimacy, charting the desperate measures characters take when emotional connection gives way.

segments where the irony and indictment arise from the same organic root, Bhardwaj's piece suffers from a tonal schism. The whimsical, almost theatrical humour frequently works at cross-purposes with the gravity of the social commentary. The segment struggles to translate the couple's real-life chemistry, feeling more performative than passionately felt.

Kiran Rao frames lust as an extension of urban ambition in the metropolis. What begins as a raw, electrifying connection between a gig worker and a nail artist swiftly unravels when a hidden windfall literally spills from a closet behind the mirror. This sudden, surreal intrusion of money strips the romance of its passion. However, like Bhardwaj's take, the short doesn't fully bridge the gap between what it means and what it actually shows. When the subtext and the surface narrative don't fully synchronise, the narrative loses its grip.

Lust Stories 3 is currently streaming on Netflix

The Uprising

**Director:** Paul Greengrass

**Cast:** Andrew Garfield, Jamie Bell, Stephen Dillane, Tom Hollander, Cosmo Jarvis, Thomasin McKenzie, Jonny Lee Miller, Woody Norman, Katherine Waterston

**Storyline:** A farmer's protest against taxes strikes the match for a revolution



Thrilling retelling

English

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Written and directed by Paul Greengrass, this retelling of the Peasants' Revolt of 1381 is gripping till the strange epilogue, which shoehorns Robin Hood into the story. Till then, the film moves quickly, echoing present-day concerns of inequality and the wasteful lives of the rich. Greengrass's trademark style of handheld camera work and sweeping drone shots drags and keeps you in the mud, grime and betrayals as the story unfolds.

The Black Death that wiped out 50% of the population has caused the coffers to run dry. King Richard II (Woody Norman) is only 14-years-old and tormented by nightmares of being set upon by hoards of screaming demons. The council, ruling in the king's name, realises the church and merchants cannot be taxed and decide to increase taxes on the already burdened peasants. A farmer, Ploughman (Andrew Garfield) who lost his wife and two children to the plague, attacks and kills a soldier, when he is asked to pay a death tax for his family as there is no record of him having already paid it. This proves the spark that sets the fires of revolt ablaze. John Ball (Jamie Bell), a priest condemned by the church for his progressive views, and Wat Tyler (Cosmo Jarvis), a soldier who served under the king's father, lead the rebellion. The battles are tightly

staged, giving the viewer a sense of urgency and desperation of these men and women fighting for their lives and beliefs. The toll of the battle in terms of lives lost is there for all to see in the pile of bodies on the field. The unremittingly dun-coloured vistas present us with a very different England from William Blake's "green and pleasant land." Not even the palace or the nobility is painted in jewel tones, though the queen mother, Joan of Kent (Katherine Waterston) has her hair encompassed with a deliciously delicate and accurate gold net. The cast, comprising some of the best and brightest actors, is riveting. From Jonny Lee Miller's wily mayor, William Walworth, to Tom Hollander as one of the king's men, Sir Robert Hales, and Dónal Finn as a priest sympathetic to the peasants' cause, there is a joy in watching them

immersed in their characters. Garfield embodies Ploughman's heartbreak and strength right down to the scars of the bubonic plague on his neck. Bell is fire and zeal, while Jarvis brings the weight of a soldier's experience. It is only the Robin Hood-shaped epilogue that causes the film to trip up. Making *The Uprising* a Robin Hood origin story makes it look like the Peasants' Revolt was not thrilling or accessible enough on its own. Also, there is the small matter of historical accuracy – Robin Hood is traditionally attached to Richard the Lion Heart and the Crusades in the late 12<sup>th</sup> century. It is an unnecessary blemish on an otherwise perfect tale of desperate men on both sides fighting to keep what they think is their right.

The Uprising is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Biopic on R&AW founder and spymaster RN Kao announced

Dharma Productions and Leo Media Collective announced a biopic on Rameshwar Nath Kao, the spymaster who founded the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) in 1968. Currently in the development stage, the film is set to be released in theatres on August 11, 2028, ahead of Independence Day. Notably, 2028 will mark 60 years of the Indian external intelligence agency. Billed as a large-scale espionage actioner, the film is based on Nitin Gokhale's book *Gentleman Spymaster*. According to a press release, the film will chronicle Kao's journey from 1955 to 1971, from establishing the need for R&AW to leading to its formation and the first-ever mission in the 1971 war against Pakistan.



Waheeda Rehman to play Gandhi's mother

Veteran actor Waheeda Rehman has joined Sudhir Mishra's upcoming film on Mohandas Gandhi. Known for starring in classics like *Guide*, *Pyaasa*, *Kaagaz Ke Phool*, *Teesri Kasam*, and *Khamoshi*, the veteran actor will play the role of Gandhi's mother, Putlibai, in the period film which features Manoj Bajpayee playing the freedom fighter. Speaking about it, Sudhir said in a statement, "I have such a deep and personal connection with films like *Pyaasa*, *Sahib Bibi Aur Ghulam*, *Kaagaz Ke Phool* and *Guide*. I grew up watching these films." The currently untitled film explores a lesser-known 21-day chapter from Gandhi's life.



Rohit Shetty's Golmaal 5 gets release date

The release date of Rohit Shetty's upcoming multistarrer comedy-drama, *Golmaal 5*, was announced by the makers recently. The film will hit the screens on January 8, 2027. It stars Ajay Devgn, Akshay Kumar, Shreyas Talpade, Arshad Warsi, Tusshar Kapoor and Sharman Joshi in pivotal roles. The film was announced earlier this year in March with Rohit penning a long note. "20 years ago, the first 'Golmaal' was released, a film that changed my life," he wrote. *Golmaal* is one of the most successful Hindi comedy franchises. The first film was released in 2006. They all followed stories of how Ajay and his gang end up in hilarious situations and make their way out of them.



A monstrously good time

Zach Cregger turns one doomed delivery into an infectiously funny *Resident Evil* speedrun. A certified Raccoon City banger

English

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I am of the firm belief that the subgenre of Terrible, Horrible, No Good, Very Bad Day movies belongs in the Top 3 genres ever devised in the history of cinema, because there is something endlessly entertaining about watching an ordinary person discover that a manageable inconvenience has metastasised into a full-scale indictment of their existence. Zach Cregger's *Resident Evil* is his *After Hours*, except Martin Scorsese's nocturnal tribulations in Soho have been relocated to Raccoon City, where the night keeps taking increasingly grotesque T-virus liberties with the human form. Cregger could have found no better Paul Hackett for this ordeal than Austin Abrams, whose Bryan seems forever one minor affront to his peace away from needing to lie down. He is a medical courier who takes an ill-advised final delivery through a snowstorm for some extra money, hits a woman with his car, discovers that she may be a zombie, gets stopped by a policeman, loses his car, and then spends the remaining 97-minute nightmare shooting at things with comical incompetence. Bryan has the unfortunate occupational fatalism of a desperate gig worker, coupled with the survival instincts of an NPC whose principal contribution to the plot is usually a sad, little note explaining how he died. Cregger knows just how funny it is to perpetually keep him in that state, so every time Bryan acquires some semblance of control, the film periodically removes it again, usually by making him shoot at yet another comically indestructible padlock or whatever fresh biological nonsense Cregger has cooked up around the corner. Abrams plays every stage of that humiliation with aplomb. It is genuinely difficult to think of another recent performance so completely calibrated to the specific idiocy of survival-horror. Most

Resident Evil

**Director:** Zach Cregger

**Cast:** Austin Abrams, Paul Walter Hauser, Kali Reis, Zach Cherry

**Storyline:** A medical courier finds himself in a desperate fight for survival against bloodthirsty, mutated creatures

of his dialogue sounds like live commentary on his own impending death, with Bryan muttering and groaning to himself in consistent disbelief. The film had some serious franchise baggage to shake off. The six Milla Jovovich movies built their own action mythology around Capcom's games for years, while *Resident Evil: Welcome to Raccoon City* tried to steer the series back towards the first two titles. Cregger simply leaves most of that luggage behind. Leon, Ada, Claire and Wesker are nowhere to be found, and Bryan has absolutely no need to understand Umbrella's sprawling corporate pathology before he can get through the next door. Some fans understandably bristled at that choice. The funny thing is that Cregger seems to understand the *Resident Evil* games at the basest level of their most perversely specific habits. The typewriters and green herbs are obvious nods, but the gun and its ammunition being stranded in entirely different parts of the building is almost comically faithful to the games, where possessing a weapon and possessing the means to use it can feel like two unrelated achievements. Bryan keeps checking what he has, what he needs and what he can afford to waste, and Cregger understands that this inventory anxiety is part of the pleasure. Every bullet matters because there may be nothing behind the next door except something that might require six of them. There is a specificity to these little details that makes the idea of Cregger as some opportunistic *Resident Evil* larper just absurd. We already knew Cregger had a particular knack for making horror funny without draining it of its unpleasantness. *Barbarian* frightened me more, while *Weapons* made me laugh harder, so the real achievement is the confluence of those two instincts while simultaneously rebuilding the very sensory experience of playing *Resident Evil* from scratch. The film makes you think about where you are, where you have been and what you can plausibly reach before something reaches you. Cregger draws on John Carpenter and Sam Raimi for his exaggerated creature designs, and this is where his appetite for practical horror becomes especially

satisfying. He stages a full mutilated extravaganza including the alien-dog from *The Thing*; a skyborne parade of exploding corpses; a Baron Harkonnen lookalike from *Dune* whose stomach erupts into rats; and, funniest of all, the same woman Bryan first runs his car into, who pursues him through the night while repeatedly evolving into a Rat King-like grotesque. Dariusz Wolski's cinematography gives the carnage a strangely sumptuous frame that is remarkably easy on the eyes, shifting between a gorgeous play of light and shadow, lurid red hues, and anxiety-inducing POV shots that turn Bryan's field of vision into another mechanism of suspense. A minor gripe is that the film's lean runtime leaves its supporting players underfed and largely unnecessary. Once Bryan reaches Raccoon City, Paul Walter Hauser and Kali Reis have to shoulder the job of explaining the outbreak and the package he had been carrying; the story suddenly has to pause its one-man nightmare to fill in some of the larger franchise connections. The information is necessary, though the mythology never quite gathers enough weight to justify its inclusion. That said, Cregger has genuinely pulled a defining feat here. When a close friend of mine, and a resident *Resident Evil* superfan, first convinced me to give the games a shot (*RE 7: Biohazard* to be specific), I spent much of my initiation nervously screaming, crying, throwing up and progressively losing whatever remained of my dignity at the mere suggestion that something might be waiting around the corner. My incompetence was apparently the evening's entertainment for my veteran friend, who found my terror considerably funnier than I did, and it seems Cregger understands that pleasure perfectly. I think that makes *Resident Evil* one of the rare films to genuinely capture the experience of playing a game without asking you to pick up a controller. It's an extraordinarily difficult sensation to reproduce in cinema, and Cregger gets pretty damn close.

Resident Evil is currently running in theatres